The current issue and full text archive of this journal is available on Emerald Insight at:
https://www.emerald.com/insight/1356-3289.htm

Corporate Communications: An International Journal

95

Exploring communication dynamics for organisational sustainability: interconnections and impact on performance

Melis Temel, Robin von Haartman and Per Hilletofth
Department of Industrial Engineering and Sustainable Development, Faculty of Engineering and Sustainable Development, University of Gävle, Gävle, Sweden

Received 7 August 2024
Revised 12 June 2025
Accepted 18 June 2025

Abstract

Purpose – The objective of this paper is to provide insights into the significance of communication factors for sustainability practices and their interconnections within organisations. In order to achieve this, the paper explores the differences between civil society organisations (CSOs), corporations and public sector organisations (PSOs). Furthermore, it analyses the relationship between these factors and the performance of organisations in relation to environmental, social and economic sustainability.

Design/methodology/approach – A literature review was conducted to identify eight relevant communication factors. A survey was then carried out to explore sustainability integration, focusing on communication factors and sustainability performance. Data analysis included descriptive statistics, Pearson correlations, and ANOVA to identify patterns and relationships.

Findings – The results show that all communication factors are critical for organisational sustainability, with policies ranked first. The results of the correlation analyses indicate that all eight communication factors are interconnected, though the strength of these relationships varies. The reporting shows a low correlation with other communication factors. While there are statistical differences in communication factors across different types of organisations, the "policy" factor is ranked first in all three types. The results also indicate that employee engagement has a significant correlation with all three aspects of sustainability performance. The overall results show that communication factors, including leadership, employee engagement, training, diversity and inclusion, policies, vision and mission and support, have a significant impact on sustainability performance in organisations.

Practical implications – This paper explores key communication factors in sustainability, analysing their interrelations in different type of organisations and links to performance. By mapping factors such as policy, support, reporting and training, the paper highlights how integrated communication structures influence sustainability outcomes. The central roles of support and policy suggest that formal structures are vital for embedding sustainability. PSOs, CSOs and corporations can strengthen their impact through tailored strategies, such as mandatory training, cross-functional teams or incentive-based programs. Improving communication factors enables better alignment with sustainability goals, enhances employee engagement and supports more effective organisation-wide efforts to drive sustainability outcomes and broader societal impact.

Social implications – This study underscores the societal benefits of effective communication strategies for sustainability. Enhanced communication channels can promote transparency, inclusivity and stakeholder collaboration, shaping public policy and fostering community engagement. By integrating sustainability-focused factors, including leadership and support, into policy frameworks, organisations and policymakers can address sustainability challenges more cohesively. These strategies promote collective action and catalyse progress toward sustainable development goals through increased awareness and collaboration.

Originality/value – This paper provides insights into the interconnections of communication factors for sustainability in different types of organisations and their relationship with performance, emphasising the need for a holistic and integrated approach.

Keywords Organisational sustainability, Communication, Sustainability performance, Communication factors, Communication for sustainability

Paper type Research article

© Melis Temel, Robin von Haartman and Per Hilletofth. Published by Emerald Publishing Limited. This article is published under the Creative Commons Attribution (CC BY 4.0) license. Anyone may reproduce, distribute, translate and create derivative works of this article (for both commercial and non-commercial purposes), subject to full attribution to the original publication and authors. The full terms of this license may be seen at Link to the terms of the CC BY 4.0 licence.

Corporate Communications: An International Journal
Vol. 30 No. 7, 2025
pp. 95-120
Emerald Publishing Limited
e-ISSN: 1758-6046
p-ISSN: 1356-3289
DOI 10.1108/CCIJ-01-2025-0004

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

1. Introduction

The importance of sustainability in organisations has increased during the last three decades (Moldavska and Welo, 2018; Tsalis *et al*., 2022). Organisations [civil society organisations (CSOs), corporate sector and public sector organisations (PSOs)] have begun to engage with their stakeholders on sustainability practices and communicate their sustainability performance by integrating sustainability aspects into their systems to support organisational sustainability and meet societal expectations (Crane and Glozer, 2016; Traxler *et al*., 2020).

Communication has a key role in sharing an organisation's sustainability efforts and establishing effective channels with stakeholders (Kang and Kim, 2017; Ortas *et al*., 2017; Yang and Basile, 2022) and is a relatively new research area, but increasingly receiving more attention in the literature (Golob *et al*., 2022; Verk *et al*., 2021). Organisations have utilised various channels such as annual reports, websites, TV and print media to communicate their sustainability efforts and practices to demonstrate their contributions to a sustainable society and address stakeholder concerns (Farneti and Guthrie, 2009; Klettner *et al*., 2014; Schaefer *et al*., 2020). Beyond its role in information exchange, communication is essential to foster organisational commitment and sustainable practices, while removing barriers to participatory changes (Petrini and Pozzebon, 2010) and addressing the complex sustainability challenges (Genç, 2017; Newig *et al*., 2013).

In addition to sustainability practices, communication also plays an important role in sustainability outcomes (Garay *et al*., 2017; Yang and Basile, 2022). The research has mostly focused on the effects on environmental performance in corporations (Golob *et al*., 2022; Ohlsson and Riihimäki, 2015), followed by social performance (Lodhia, 2014; Papoutsi and Sodhi, 2020) and economic performance (Oncioiu *et al*., 2020). Investigations tend to concentrate on a single aspect of sustainability performance and communication (Devin and Lane, 2014; Golob *et al*., 2022).

While the importance of communication in organisational sustainability is recognised, most research has focused on corporations (Ceulemans *et al*., 2015). Studies have explored topics such as web-use for sustainability communication (Lodhia, 2014); its impact on employee perceptions and sustainability behaviours (Schaefer *et al*., 2020), developing frameworks under corporate social responsibility (CSR) (Crane and Glozer, 2016; Du *et al*., 2010; Fernández *et al*., 2022; Ji *et al*., 2022) and the role of sustainability communication in the attitude–behaviour gap (Tölkes, 2020). However, there is limited research on other types of organisations (Alon *et al*., 2010; Ceulemans *et al*., 2015; Ho Lee, 2017). Specifically, there is a notable scarcity of research examining the interplay of multiple communication factors and their impact on sustainability initiatives across organisations.

Literature review studies have shown that one or two communication factors have been considered in the literature, which limits a comprehensive understanding of communication's role in sustainability in organisations (Golob *et al*., 2022; Nanath and Ajit Kumar, 2021; Nwagbara and Reid, 2013). This shows that there is an important gap in the literature regarding a holistic approach to communication factors for sustainability in various types of organisations beyond the corporate sector.

The purpose of this paper is to provide insights into the importance of communication factors for sustainability practices and their interconnections in organisations. The paper explores differences in communication factors among the different organisation types (CSOs, corporations and PSOs). The paper also analyses how these factors relate to sustainability performance (environmental, social and economic).

Initially, a literature review on communication factors relevant to sustainability was undertaken in this study. Subsequently, eight communication factors were identified and compiled. Each factor was selected based on its recurring importance across relevant studies and its conceptual relevance to sustainability communication (see references provided in the literature review). To address the research purpose, a survey was conducted. The collected data underwent analysis using descriptive statistics, comparison of mean values (rankings) and

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

comparisons between organisation types, alongside correlations and centrality to better understand the relationships between communication factors and sustainability performance.

This paper is structured as follows: Section 2 presents an overview of the literature on communication factors for sustainability and sustainability performance; Section 3 outlines the methods; Section 4 shows the survey results, while Section 5 discusses these results. Finally, Section 6 draws conclusions from the study, highlighting its contributions to the field and suggesting directions for future research.

2. Literature review

2.1 Communication factors for sustainability

Various communication factors can be found in the literature to embed sustainability into the systems of organisations (Carpenter *et al*., 2016; Franz-Balsen and Heinrichs, 2007; Hahn and Kühnen, 2013; Hörisch *et al*., 2015; Lodhia, 2014). Through a literature review, eight communication factors for sustainability in organisations have been found (Table 1). These factors are instrumental in shaping how organisations interpret and implement sustainability practices, influencing from decision-making processes to stakeholder engagement. Despite recognition of their individual roles, their importance and relationships among these factors remain under-researched. There is a need for a more integrated approach that covers all aspects of sustainability performance in diverse organisational contexts.

Leadership is a crucial driver for sustainability to enhance resilience, organisational and sustainability performance (Domingues *et al*., 2017; Liao, 2022). Leadership establishes effective communication channels to bring together individuals from diverse backgrounds (Carpenter *et al*., 2016). This shapes and implements sustainability initiatives (Rieg *et al*., 2021). Leadership highlights the need for continuous communication for sustainability principles by using both formal and informal channels, and getting constructive feedback in corporations (Quinn and Dalton, 2009). While there is existing research on leadership for sustainability in CSOs (Allen, 2020; Filho *et al*., 2020), studies in PSOs remain limited (Batulan *et al*., 2021).

Reporting is a widely used tool to communicate sustainable practices and policies with stakeholders, driven by the demand for transparency (de Oliveira *et al*., 2023; Verk *et al*., 2021). This demand has led to the development of reporting tools to measure sustainability and enhance stakeholder involvement (Amey *et al*., 2020; Kaur and Lodhia, 2019). Regions with advanced digital infrastructure may adopt more sophisticated digital communication tools, while others may rely on traditional methods, impacting the effectiveness of sustainability reporting (Covucci *et al*., 2024). Digital tools, such as dashboards and online reporting systems, enable organisations to measure, report and communicate their sustainability efforts effectively. By aligning missions, objectives and strategies with control mechanisms facilitated through reporting, organisations can enhance their sustainability performance (Traxler *et al*., 2020). In PSOs, sustainability reporting is utilised as a mechanism for both stakeholder engagement and change, despite inconsistencies in its implementation (Domingues *et al*., 2017; Farneti and Guthrie, 2009). While some CSOs report on sustainability practices, the number and the quality of such reports are still limited and fragmented (Ceulemans *et al*., 2015).

Employee engagement enhances organisational efficiency and positive outcomes at both individual and organisational levels, highlighting the importance of accessible information and communication (Harter *et al*., 2002; Kate Nnabuife *et al*., 2015; Verburg *et al*., 2018). Involved employees proactively identify, communicate and follow opportunities to address sustainability issues in corporations (Fletcher *et al*., 2016). Fostering active employee participation is also crucial to recognise their commitment to sustainability by enhancing organisational satisfaction and sustainability initiatives in PSOs (Crane and Glozer, 2016; Hohnen, 2007). Employee engagement in universities for sustainability can be enhanced through organisational leadership, support, role models and the provision of time, financial

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Table 1. Summary of communication factors for sustainability

Communication factors for sustainability	Description	References
1. Leadership	Improves organisational resilience and performance, fostering effective communication and collaboration, while balancing economic, social and environmental aspects	Javed *et al*. (2021), Suriyankietkaew and Avery (2014)
2. Reporting	Voluntary initiative, known as sustainability reporting, corporate sustainability reporting, CSR reporting, sustainable development reporting or environment, social and governance reporting involves assessment and communication of an organisational sustainability efforts and progress	Amran and Ooi (2014), Crane and Glozer (2016), Devin and Lane (2014), Farneti and Guthrie (2009), Hidayah *et al*. (2019), Ibáñez-Forés *et al*. (2022), Ramos *et al*. (2021)
3. Employee engagement	Catalyses transformative ideas and operational efficiency, tackling sustainability challenges and addressing positive impacts at multiple organisational levels	Aiswarya and Ramasundaram (2020), Crane and Glozer (2016), Hohnen (2007)
4. Policy	Defines an organisation's social responsibility and integrates sustainability into its culture and strategy	Hutchins and Sutherland (2008), Moneva *et al*. (2007), Van Grinsven and Visser (2011)
5. Training	Transforms sustainability resources, enhances sustainability efforts and links these activities to financial performance	Batulan *et al*. (2021), Székely and Knirsch (2005)
6. Vision/mission	Directs sustainability strategies, promotes communication and ensures the integration of sustainability into business operations and policies	Amey *et al*. (2020), Becodo (2018), Klein *et al*. (2020), Millar *et al*. (2012)
7. Support	Demonstrates organisational sustainability values, establishes partnerships and shapes attitudes and sustainability outcomes	Basil *et al*. (2011), Saz-Gil *et al*. (2020)
8. Diversity and Inclusion	Influences sustainability performance and manages dynamics, team collaboration and organisational measurement	Buallay *et al*. (2022), Gehrels and Suleri (2016), Horak *et al*. (2018), Khatri (2023)

Source(s): Authors' own work

resources and reward systems to facilitate learning, resource sharing and curriculum redesign (Cebrián *et al*., 2015). In CSOs, specific stakeholders, such as local communities, actively engage as "partners" in implementing sustainability activities (Hayman, 2016).

Policy is reviewed as a foundational framework to guide an organisation's social interactions and sustainability outcomes (Moneva *et al*., 2007; Sánchez *et al*., 2020). An integrated sustainability policy is more effective rather than as a separate policy (Klettner *et al*., 2014). Clear sustainability policies bridge the information gaps with stakeholders and align employees with organisation's commitment to knowledge-sharing (Schaefer *et al*., 2020; Van Grinsven and Visser, 2011). Corporations align their communication strategies with their sustainability policies (Viererbl and Koch, 2022). This includes transparent reporting and collaborative efforts, yet the lack of standardised tools can limit the adoption of sustainability information tools (Ammann *et al*., 2023; Xie *et al*., 2022). PSOs have lower adoption of sustainability policies than corporations, since such methodologies have been primarily

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

developed for the private sector (Figueira *et al*., 2018). Some institutions have used various online strategies such as policy documents, websites, social media, blogs and sustainability plans for sustainability communication (Amey *et al*., 2020).

Training is a systematic process to improve knowledge, skills, and approaches, which increases organisational competitiveness and performance (Tharenou *et al*., 2007; Zhang *et al*., 2019). Training in corporations fosters organisational learning and develops new sustainability guidelines and management systems (Encinas Bartos *et al*., 2024). For instance, training about sustainability influences suppliers to adopt eco-friendly practices and improve their long-term performance, while motivating to solve complex sustainability problems (Oelze *et al*., 2016; van Hoof, 2014; Zhao *et al*., 2022). Prioritising regular training in PSOs strengthens inclusive workplaces and sustainability reporting processes (Domingues *et al*., 2017; Figueira *et al*., 2018). Universities and other CSOs give less emphasis to training on sustainability practices and performance due to a lack of personnel training (Briguglio and Brown, 2011; Leal Filho *et al*., 2021).

Vision and mission is crucial for organisations to guide their sustainability strategies and manage stakeholders' expectations (Amran *et al*., 2014). Communication between leaders and members is essential to realise the vision and mission, and to increase sustainability knowledge (Becodo, 2018). Vision for sustainability motivates and guides individuals and organisations towards sustainable practices (Millar *et al*., 2012). This fosters commitment and transition towards sustainable change. Corporations with a clear vision and mission provide better sustainability knowledge than those focused only on shareholders (Moneva *et al*., 2007). Establishing a holistic vision with specific guidelines is a fundamental step for guiding PSOs toward sustainability transitions (Klein *et al*., 2021). Similarly, a well-defined vision and mission can assist CSOs in managing sustainability plans (Amey *et al*., 2020), while a lack of strategic communication limits stakeholder awareness (Mazo and Macpherson, 2017).

Support is vital to enhance team performance and motivation by providing training and development opportunities (Chiraz and Frioui, 2012; Opoku-Dakwa *et al*., 2018). Guidance and support build trust, employee engagement and encourage eco-friendly behaviours (Basil *et al*., 2011; Çop *et al*., 2021). A supportive work environment improves organisational performance (Hossin *et al*., 2021; Lyu, 2024; Zhao *et al*., 2022). In the context of sustainability, support refers to leadership and organisational practices that empower employees through access to training, resources and a workplace culture that fosters sustainable thinking and behaviours (Liao, 2022). Challenges, however, such as insufficient organisational support and leadership, negative environments and the absence of role models or champions, can hinder sustainability integration in curricula and overall progress (Cebrián *et al*., 2015; Shawe *et al*., 2019). Support can also include services provided by municipalities to address social, economic and environmental issues in their local communities (Tetrevova and Jelinkova, 2019).

Diversity and inclusion play a significant role in sustainability performance to overcome different cultural barriers (Horak *et al*., 2018). Diversity refers to the presence of differences within a given setting, particularly in terms of gender, ethnicity, age and background, while inclusion is the practice of ensuring that these diverse individuals are actively engaged, valued and integrated into decision-making processes (Galletta *et al*., 2022). Sustainability-driven corporations often implement diversity programs for employees at all levels, from recent graduates to senior employees, to promote sustainability (Saz-Gil *et al*., 2020). Diversity varies by industry, size and region (Kompa and Witkowska, 2018), yet board diversity improves environmental, social performance and reporting transparency (Buallay *et al*., 2022; Khatri, 2023). Diversity and inclusion are also key for PSOs to assess sustainability performance (Figueira *et al*., 2018). Regarding CSOs, a comprehensive approach to diversity and inclusion requires funding and internal systems (Hayman, 2016), but a specific link to the existing structures and systems remains unclear (Franz-Balsen and Heinrichs, 2007).

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

2.2 Impact of communication factors on performance

Sustainability performance covers environmental, social and economic outcomes (Foo *et al*., 2018). Sustainability performance is a critical metric for various stakeholders and organisations (Papoutsi and Sodhi, 2020; Silva *et al*., 2019). Environmental performance evaluates an organisation's impact on the environment, including resource use, pollution prevention, waste minimisation, compliance with regulations and eco-friendly actions (Ameer and Khan, 2020; Huo *et al*., 2019). Economic performance includes various indicators such as investments in development and profit. Social performance assesses how organisations contribute to society beyond economic interests, demonstrating corporate social responsibility to multiple stakeholders (Foo *et al*., 2018; Huo *et al*., 2019).

In the literature, as seen in Figure 1, there are limited studies on communication factors and sustainability performance (Verk *et al*., 2021), often focusing on individual performance aspects. Sustainable leadership, for example, has been found to influence sustainability performance by encouraging open sharing of ideas and information among employees (Iqbal *et al*., 2020b; Suriyankietkaew and Avery, 2014) as well as having a significant effect through organisational learning (Iqbal *et al*., 2020a). Training increases environmental performance by enhancing awareness, and reducing waste and energy consumption (Albrecht *et al*., 2022; Morrow and Rondinelli, 2002). While some studies have identified an impact of sustainability reporting on corporate performance, particularly in energy, water and safety (Khunkaew *et al*., 2023), and economic performance (Oncioiu *et al*., 2020), others have found no relationship due to variations in reporting years and obligations across countries (Khunkaew *et al*., 2023). The connection between training, policies and sustainability performance in PSOs emphasises the need for investment in training programs and the development of comprehensive policies to enhance overall sustainability performance (Figueira *et al*., 2018). Other connections in studies are shown in the figure below.

3. Research method

In this paper, an online survey was developed with a specific focus on communication. The online survey platform Qualtrics was used for data collection and was conducted between May and December 2023. The survey was structured into four sections to comprehensively explore various aspects of sustainability integration in organisations: (1) General information about organisations, including size and sector; (2) Role of sustainability and respondents in the organisation; (3) Sustainability questions, including communication factors; and (4) Sustainability performance questions. The survey instrument was developed by the research team through a thorough review of existing literature on sustainability communication and sustainability performance. This study uses data from Sections 1, 3 and 4. In total, the survey contained 74 questions, the majority of which were closed-ended using Likert-type scales, with a few open-ended items. The survey was distributed using the Qualtrics XM database and included three reminders. A pre-test was conducted with several sustainability professionals across sectors to evaluate the clarity, relevance and length of the questionnaire. Feedback led to minor revisions, including simplifying terminology and adjusting the layout for better usability.

A stratified random sampling method was used, categorising organisations by type (corporations, PSOs and CSOs) and size (Figure 2). Sweden was chosen as the focus of this study because of its advanced sustainability practices, strong institutional framework and progressive corporate governance culture. The country is often seen as a leader in sustainability reporting and policy, making it an appropriate context for examining the communication dynamics associated with sustainability integration. Approximately 1,200 organisations were randomly chosen from among the several thousand organisations in Sweden, using the Retriever database. About 33% of them were excluded for the following reasons: (1) the organisation was no longer operational (e.g. bankruptcy or permanent closure); (2) it did not align with the sampling criteria (e.g. was outside the defined sectors or

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

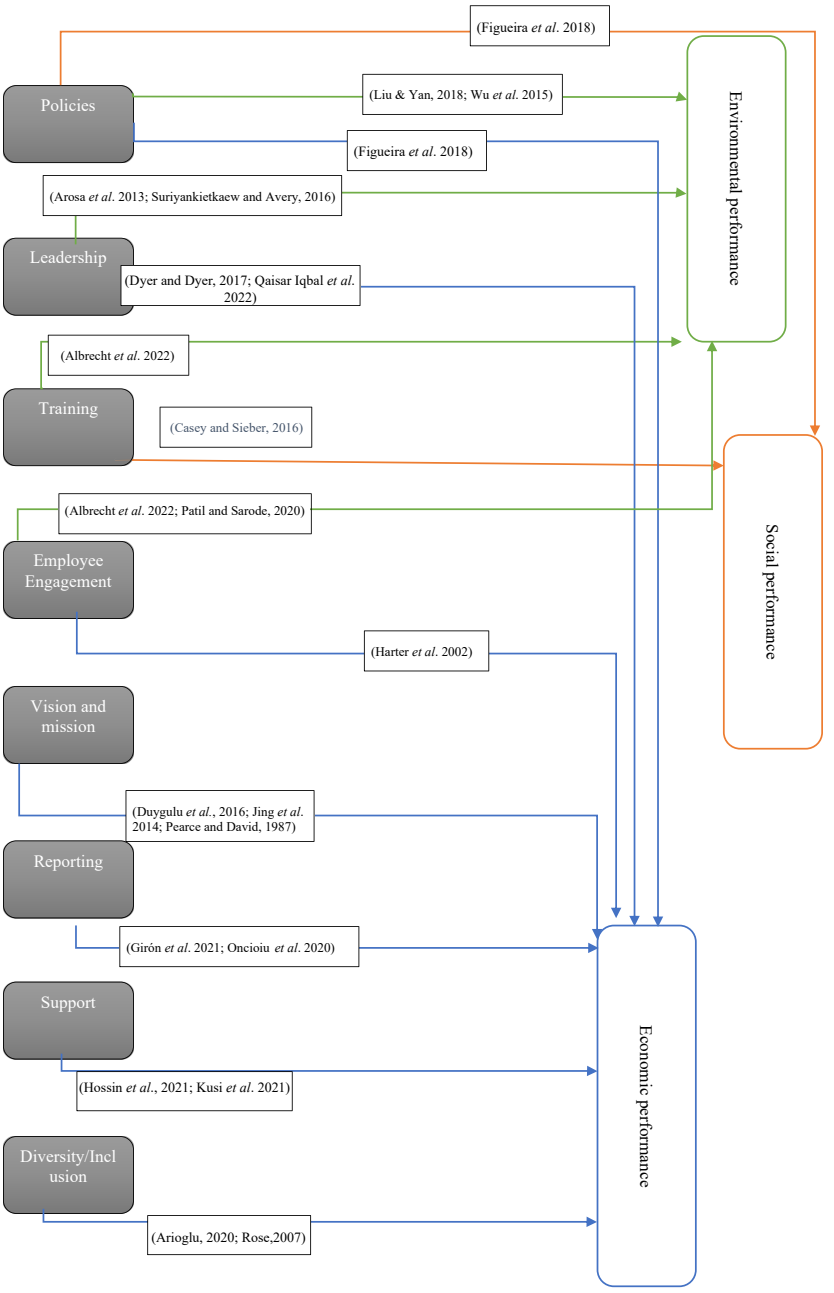


Figure 1. The link between communication factors and sustainability performance. **Source:** Authors' own work

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

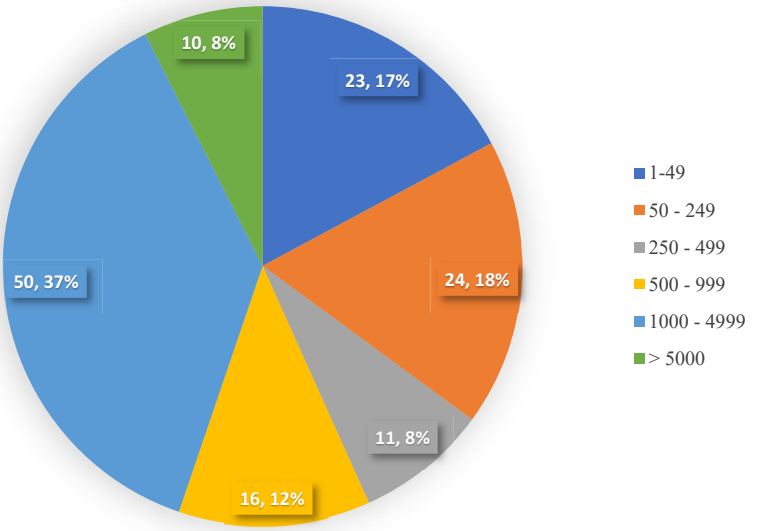


Figure 2. The number of employees in organisations. **Source:** Authors' own work

based outside Sweden); or (3) it had incorrect or unusable contact details (e.g. invalid email addresses or phone numbers). These exclusions ensured the sample remained consistent with the study's target population.

Approximately 800 were contacted via telephone. Among those contacted, 60% organisations agreed to participate, resulting in around 500 invitations sent via email. The email list specifically included people who hold positions actively involved in sustainability efforts. These roles included leadership positions such as sustainability manager and broader titles like corporate sustainability leader or even global sustainability manager. However, some emails never reached their audience, due to erroneous addresses or firewalls, which resulted in 441 organisations in the final sample. 115 organisations provided full responses. To mitigate the risk of non-response bias, we conducted a correlation analysis between the survey completion date and all other variables: no statistically significant correlations were found.

According to the respondents, there were 23 organisations with 1–49 employees, 24 with 50–249 employees, 9 with 240–499 employees, 16 with 500–999 employees, 50 with 1,000–4,999 employees and 9 with more than 5,000 employees (refer to Figure 2).

How long respondents have worked with sustainability is shown in Figure 3. This indicates that a significant majority have more than 10 years, followed by those with 5–10 years and those with 1–5 years of experience. Respondents' characteristics were assessed using a four-point scale, indicating the duration of involvement in sustainability: less than 1 year, 1–5 years, 5–10 years and more than 10 years.

The communication questions were as follows: whether the organisation's communication factors, which include sustainability reporting, policies, leadership, diversity, employee engagement, training, support, vision and mission, focus on sustainability practices? Respondents used the following five-point scale for their answers: "Definitely not", "Probably not", "Possibly yes or no", "Probably yes" and "Definitely yes". It should be noted that the sustainability performance was evaluated on a scale over the past five years. Performance was measured by asking the respondent to rate the change experienced in the last

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

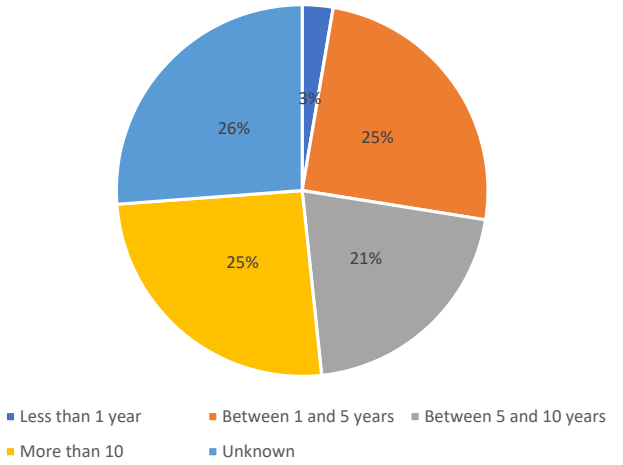


Figure 3. The duration of participants' involvement in sustainability efforts. **Source:** Authors' own work

5 years, in 12 areas related to environmental, social and economic sustainability, on a 9-point scale ranging from much worse to much better (Table 4).

The data were analysed using descriptive statistics, Pearson correlations and centrality analysis. Descriptive statistics serve as a statistical approach to summarise large datasets, which present patterns and facilitats comparisons across different groups (Jupp, 2006). In this paper, descriptive statistics were conducted to define individuals and social groups on key variables, which helped rank the communication factors for sustainability based on their significance.

ANOVA (Analysis of Variance) is a statistical method used to compare means across multiple groups to determine whether observed differences are statistically significant (Bryman, 2012; Walliman, 2011). Here, an ANOVA test was used to analyse variance between multiple groups by assessing performance differences across various categories. This test evaluated potential statistical differences in communication factors among different organisation types (CSOs, corporations, and PSOs).

Pearson correlation measures the strength and direction of the relationship between two variables (Bryman, 2012; Walliman, 2011). In this study, Pearson correlation analyses examined the relationship between communication factors and sustainability performance, as the data followed a normal distribution. To visually represent correlations, a Network Map (NM) was created using yEd software (yED, 2019), which employs centrality analysis to identify the relative importance of factors within a network. This technique provides insights into the relationships between different topics and the impact of one idea on another. This process helped identify noticeable issues by measuring linkages and balance among categories (Borgatti, 2005). All statistical analyses were performed using SPSS 24 and yEd. These tools provided comprehensive insights into the data, revealing patterns and relationships critical to understanding the role of communication factors in sustainability efforts.

4. Limitations

While the methodology employed is robust and grounded in a solid theoretical foundation, some limitations should be acknowledged. First, the geographic focus on one country (Sweden) may restrict the generalisability of the findings to other regions with differing cultural, economic or regulatory contexts. Second, the survey may not encompass all communication factors relevant to sustainability in organisations. Lastly, the inclusion of

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

different types of organisations (corporations, PSOs and CSOs) broadens the scope of the study, enhancing external validity. However, this diversity may reduce the depth of insights for specific organisational categories.

5. Results

This section presents the results of analyses, categorised into rankings, correlations and centrality measures for all organisations in the study: corporations (26), CSOs (14) and PSOs (77).

5.1 Ranking communication factors for organisations

Figure 4 presents mean values of the communication factors for sustainability in organisations, ranked from highest to lowest. The results show that the policy holds the highest mean value with a score of 3.95, closely followed by vision and mission at 3.85, and employee participation at 3.64. Leadership and reporting received a rating of 3.58 and 3.46, respectively, while the lowest mean value was training with 3.38.

ANOVA test was also performed to compare the statistical differences between the communication factors across the three types of organisations (CSOs, corporations and PSOs) as detailed in Table 2. The test shows that there are statistically significant differences between the three types of organisations in three out of the eight factors of communication (diversity and inclusion, support and leadership). It should be noted that corporations had the highest mean rank in all the communication factors that showed statistical differences.

Table 2 also presents the ranking of communication factors in order of importance (mean values) for each organisation type. Policies emerged as the top-ranked factor for all three types of organisations: corporations (4.31), CSOs (3.91) and PSOs (3.792). Lowest-ranked communication factors were diversity and inclusion (3.25 for both CSOs and PSOs) and support (3.27 for both of these organisations). Training was the lowest ranked for corporations, with a score of 3.42, followed by employee engagement with 3.62.

In addition to diversity and inclusion, the largest difference among organisation types was seen in employee engagement, which ranked seventh for corporations, fourth for CSOs and

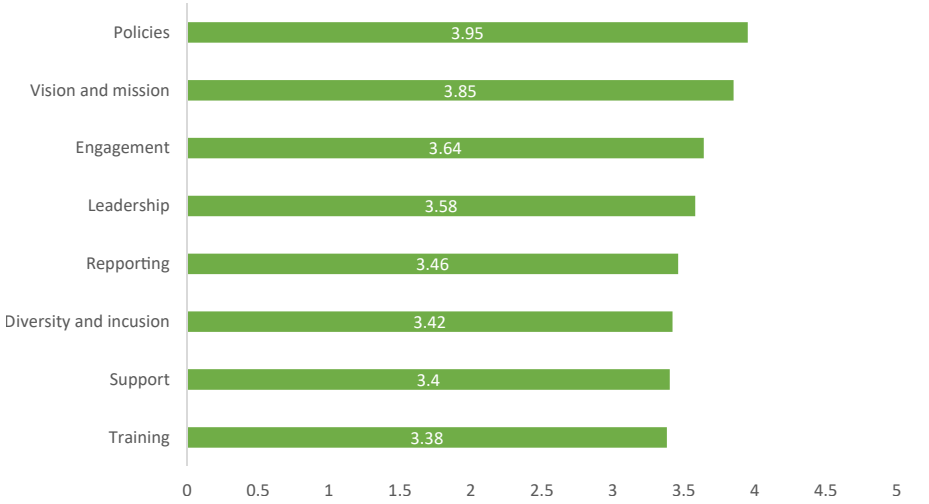


Figure 4. The mean values of communication factors for sustainability in organisations as indicators of significance, $N = 115$, ANOVA $p < 0.01$. **Source:** Authors' own work

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Table 2. Mean values for communication factors, ranked from highest to lowest for different organisation types

Rank	CSO (N:11)	Corporations (N:26)	PSOs (N:76)
1	Polices (3.91)	Policies (4.31)	Policies (3.82)
2	Leadership (3.82)	Leadership (4.15)	Vision and mission (3.81)
3	Vision and mission (3.73)	Vision and mission (4.00)	Employee engagement (3.65)
4	Employee engagement (3.64)	Diversity and inclusion (3.96)	Reporting (3.36)
5	Training (3.36)	Support (3.77)	Training (3.34)
6	Reporting (3.27)	Reporting (3.69)	Leadership (3.34)
7	Support (3.27)	Employee engagement (3.62)	Support (3.27)
8	Diversity and inclusion (3.25)	Training (3.42)	Diversity and inclusion (3.25)

Source(s): Authors' own work

third for PSOs. Leadership also showed differences in these organisations, such as the second position for CSOs and corporations, but took the sixth position for PSOs. The remaining factors held similar rankings across the three types, consistent with the results of the ANOVA.

5.2 Correlations among communication factors

The strength of the connection among communication factors is presented in Table 3 using Pearson's correlation analysis. The results show that all identified correlations between the studied factors are statistically significant at the $p < 0.01$ level. High correlations (0.70–0.4 in dark blue) were observed between support and leadership, support and diversity and inclusion, and leadership and diversity and inclusion. Moderate correlations (0.4–0.25 in light blue) were between employee engagement and diversity and inclusion, between policies and leadership and between policies and training. Factors with low or no correlation values (between 0.25 and 0.1) were highlighted in red. Leadership showed a high correlation with support (0.636), while the correlation between vision and mission and reporting was the lowest at 0.115.

Table 3. Correlations between communication factors in organisations ($n = 115$; Pearson's correlation test, $p < 0.01$), Strongest links in dark blue, moderate in blue, weakest in red

	Leadership	Reporting	Policies	Training	Support	Employee engagement	Diversity and inclusion	Vision and mission
Leadership	1							
Reporting	0.283	1						
Policies	0.532	0.29	1					
Training	0.477	0.28	0.501	1				
Support	0.636	0.276	0.48	0.551	1			
Employee engagement	0.385	0.311	0.268	0.401	0.594	1		
Diversity and inclusion	0.596	0.353	0.356	0.497	0.609	0.538	1	
Vision and mission	0.488	0.115*	0.564	0.402	0.389	0.265	0.435	1

Note(s): *shows no correlation
Source(s): Authors' own work

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

The connections between the communication factors and their centrality are seen in Figure 5, where support has the highest centrality (1.0), indicating a strong interconnection. The policy (0.93) and diversity and inclusion (0.91) also show high centrality, whilst vision (0.76), employee engagement (0.74) and reporting (0.70) demonstrate the lowest centrality in organisations. The centrality score quantifies how well-connected a factor is within the network, with higher scores indicating stronger ties with other factors.

Factors with the highest correlations are highlighted by dark blue squares; medium links with purple. Those with the lowest correlations are represented in light purple and grey. The node size in the network map presents each factor's centrality: larger nodes signify greater centrality and a more significant role in the network, whereas smaller nodes indicate lesser centrality.

5.3 Correlations between communication factors and sustainability performance

Considering the respondents' answers, the correlation between communication factors and sustainability performance is shown in Table 4. The table highlights significant correlations. This provides insights into the potential influence of communication factors on sustainability outcomes in organisations.

Some communication factors are correlated with sustainability performance, but some have a higher correlation than others according to Pearson analysis. The cells indicating a high relative correlation (0.2–0.35) include examples such as between economic performance (1) and policies (0.297), and between economic performance (4) and policies. A relatively moderate correlation (0.10–0.20) is observed between social performance (4) and leadership (0.178). Relatively low or no correlations (0.10−0.15) are seen between environmental performance (2) and diversity and inclusion (0.048). It should be noted that all correlation values below 0.2 are not statistically significant.

6. Discussion

The results of this study highlight the role of multiple communication factors – such as policies, leadership, vision and mission, support and training – in advancing sustainability performance across organisations. While leadership emerged as a particularly central factor, it is important to clarify that leadership is positioned within the broader concept of communication factors in this study. This positioning ensures that leadership remains an integral part of the overall communication framework.

The results indicate that the policy factor was ranked as the most focused on sustainability issues across all organisations, followed by vision and mission, which expands the conceptualisation of communication for sustainability (see Carpenter *et al.*, 2016; Golob

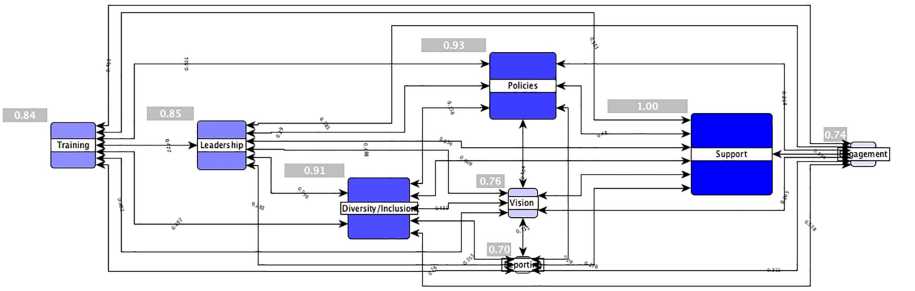


Figure 5. Centrality network map showing interconnections among communication factors, with dark blue indicating factors with the highest correlations, purple for medium connections, and light purple and grey colours representing factors with the lowest correlation; Larger nodes represent greater centrality and importance in the network, while smaller nodes show lesser centrality. **Source:** Authors' own work

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Table 4. Correlations between communication factors and sustainability performance (Pearson's correlation analysis)

	Environmental performance (1)- total emissions to air, land, and water	Environmental performance (2)- total greenhouse gas emissions	Environmental performance (3)- water consumption	Environmental performance (4)- energy consumption	Social performance (1)-(gender diversity)	Social performance (2)-Career development and training	Social performance (3)-Participation in decision-making	-Social performance (4)-Number of workplace accidents	Economic performance (1)-Productivity	Economic performance (2)-Operational costs	Economic performance (3)-Investments in research and development	Economic performance (4)-investments in training/developing employees
Leadership	0.246*	0.131	0.048	0.111	0.055	−0.094	−0.085	0.178	0.207*	0.158	0.177	0.113
Reporting	0.059	0.052	−0.043	−0.091	0.083	0.124	−0.086	0.021	0.056	−0.005	−0.178	−0.059
Policies	0.091	−0.039	0.078	−0.045	0.047	−0.145	−0.165	0.112	0.297**	0.217*	0.028	0.288**
Training	0.115	0.036	0.081	−0.078	0.026	−0.059	−0.234*	0.078	0.147	−0.019	0.048	0.317**
Support	0.153	0.148	0.118	0.138	−0.035	−0.195	−0.156	0.172	0.259*	0.13	−0.026	0.122
Employee Engagement	0.230*	0.14	0.032	0.017	−0.044	−0.203*	−0.229*	−0.029	0.085	0.232*	0.079	0.087
Diversity and Inclusion	0.212*	0.086	0.078	0.057	−0.086	−0.107	−0.200*	0.194	0.021	0.127	0.132	0.104
Vision and mission	0.138	0.095	−0.014	0.058	0.145	−0.143	−0.058	0.115	0.202	0.145	0.136	0.248*

Note(s): *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$. $n = 115$

Source(s): Authors' own work

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

et al., 2022; Viererbl and Koch, 2022). Despite extensive discussion in sustainability literature, training ranked lowest. This could be due to its frequent association with other organisational priorities, such as quality and productivity, rather than a direct focus on sustainability. Inadequate financial support and the lack of standardised training data (see Figueira *et al*., 2018; Leal Filho *et al*., 2021; Zhang *et al*., 2019) may also contribute to this outcome.

According to the results, policy was also considered the top position across organisations. This may show that it plays a key role in bridging the sustainability information gap between organisations and employees regardless of organisation type (see Schaefer *et al*., 2020; Van Grinsven and Visser, 2011). They may also reflect the influence of both external regulatory pressures and internal governance mechanisms. In the Swedish context, where policies support transparency and alignment with stakeholder expectations, they are part of a broader system of sustainability practices, as stated by Arvidsson and Dumay (2022). Sustainability practices are highly institutionalised and organisations frequently adopt formal sustainability policies to meet national expectations.

In addition to policy, the results show some variation across organisation types, particularly in areas such as leadership and diversity. Compared to CSOs and PSOs, corporations scored higher on these factors, which may be partly due to greater access to resources and stronger external pressures, such as investor expectations and public accountability (as stated by Buallay *et al*., 2022). These factors can encourage more formal approaches to leadership development and diversity initiatives. In contrast, CSOs and PSOs may focus more on mission-specific or administrative goals, which could result in less emphasis on these areas (see Figueira *et al*., 2018; Hayman, 2016). These differences highlight the importance of considering sector-specific contexts when interpreting sustainability communication practices.

The correlation analyses provide a detailed perspective on how communication factors correlate with each other. The highest correlation was between leadership and support. Yet vision and mission and reporting indicated the lowest correlations, contrary to the findings of Traxler *et al*. (2020). The positive correlation between leadership and support could potentially be due to the influence of a common underlying factor, organisational climate (see Dey *et al*., 2022). Leaders could set the direction and inspire action, while supportive environments create the conditions for meaningful dialogue, control mechanisms, collaboration and sustainable outcomes (see Amey *et al*., 2020; Nasreen *et al*., 2023; Quinn and Dalton, 2009). This might indicate that combining leadership with supportive practices can effectively implement sustainability communication strategies and improve areas with lower correlations.

The analysis of centrality provides a comprehensive picture of the interconnectedness between the factors, where support (although ranked in penultimate place) has the most central position. This indicates that support plays a critical bridging role, linking various sustainability communication factors and enabling the integration of sustainability into organisational practices. Its centrality may stem from its cross-cutting nature, as support often involves leadership engagement, provision of resources, training, and a workplace culture that encourages sustainable behaviour (Chiraz and Frioui, 2012; Liao, 2022). It should be noted that reporting was the least connected ones although reporting has received considerable attention in sustainability literature. This may be due to a lack of organisational awareness and specific guidelines for PSOs and CSOs (see Domingues *et al*., 2017; Dumay *et al*., 2010; Farneti and Guthrie, 2009). This gap may also be influenced by the data composition, primarily from corporations, and the voluntary nature of reporting (see Adams *et al*., 2014; Guthrie and Farneti, 2008). Corporations often operate under different regulatory and operational contexts compared to PSOs and CSOs, which may account for variations in the integration and emphasis of reporting practices. In these cases, reporting may be more of a compliance activity rather than a strategic tool for sustainability performance, leading to its low correlation with actual sustainability outcomes. The voluntary aspect of sustainability reporting could result in inconsistencies in how organisations approach and interpret sustainability reporting, thus diminishing its impact on performance.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

The results of this study clarify the dynamic relationships between various factors and sustainability performance. Some factors associated with sustainability performance as shown in Table 4 and Figure 5. Some factors are positively correlated, others are negative. Employee engagement, for instance, shows mixed results; while beneficial for productivity, it is negatively correlated with career development and decision-making. This may indicate that although employees are engaged in sustainability-related activities, their involvement may be limited to operational roles, with little influence over strategic processes or organisational decision-making. In this context, engagement may be implemented in a symbolic manner, rather than as a mechanism for empowerment. Employees may be motivated to participate in sustainability initiatives but lack access to structures that support career progression or strategic input. This suggests a potential disconnect between engagement and inclusion, highlighting the need to distinguish between surface-level participation and meaningful involvement (see Crane and Glozer, 2016; Hohnen, 2007). This issue may need further exploration, particularly to understand how engagement can be more effectively linked to empowerment and strategic inclusion.

The results strongly align with existing literature that connects diversity, support and leadership with economic performance. For instance, studies (Albrecht *et al*., 2022; Hossin *et al*., 2021; Rose, 2007) have highlighted how these factors contribute to enhanced economic outcomes by fostering inclusive environments, effective governance and strategic leadership. The aforementioned factors have been demonstrated to enhance productivity, innovation and employee satisfaction, which, in turn, contribute to economic performance.

While communication efforts focused on sustainability are sometimes associated with economic performance, this is not always the case. However, there is no evidence to suggest that an emphasis on sustainability leads to decreased economic performance. This challenges the prevailing assumption in much of the sustainability literature that prioritising sustainability may incur an economic cost. In other words, there does not appear to be an economic cost associated with prioritising sustainability, nor is there a trade-off between focusing on sustainability and achieving economic performance. This may call for a re-examination of traditional sustainability models, particularly those that portray sustainability efforts as a financial burden. The relationship between these factors and economic outcomes suggests that while diversity, support and leadership are crucial for achieving economic performance, their impact within the context of sustainability performance is less clear. Interestingly, the results reveal a weak correlation between sustainability reporting and overall sustainability performance, which is unexpected considering the emphasis placed on reporting in sustainability literature (Oncioiu *et al*., 2020). This could be influenced by regional and geographical differences. As Arvidsson and Dumay (2022) highlight, even in countries such as Sweden with strong reporting cultures, performance gains are not guaranteed. These variations could be shaped by different regulatory environments, cultural factors and economic conditions that prioritise different aspects of sustainability reporting.

Furthermore, policies and support tend to have stronger correlations with performance compared to training. Regarding environmental performance, factors such as leadership and diversity and inclusion are significantly correlated with it, especially in reducing emissions, aligning with the literature (see Iqbal *et al*., 2020a; Kusi *et al*., 2021; Suriyankietkaew and Avery, 2014). Meanwhile, policy, vision and mission are linked to social performance. Some communication factors significantly impact all three types of performance, such as employee engagement.

The results also show that, although it might be expected that a focus on sustainability would primarily improve social and environmental performance, there is a positive correlation with economic performance. This occurs even when the main focus is on sustainability, rather than on economic factors alone.

These results contribute conceptually to the evolving field of sustainability communication by emphasising that communication factors are not just support tools but integral to how sustainability is implemented and experienced within organisations. Rather than treating

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

communication as a linear or one-dimensional mechanism, this study frames it as a system of interrelated organisational practices – such as leadership, support and policy – that shape and reinforce performance outcomes.

As illustrated in Figure 6, the interconnectedness of communication-related practices with environmental, social and economic performance supports the notion that these factors do not function in isolation but influence each other dynamically.

Overall, a range of communication factors significantly affect sustainability performance in organisations. These factors correlate with various aspects of environmental, social and economic performance, suggesting their importance in effective sustainability implementation. It should be noted that although the current literature largely focuses on how communication factors affect sustainability performance in a one-directional manner, this paper highlights a mutual effect where sustainability performance may also enhance communication factors. This bidirectional relationship underscores the need for a holistic approach, acknowledging the interdependence between organisational sustainability and communication factors.

7. Conclusion

The purpose of the paper is to analyse the importance of communication factors, their interrelationship and the relationship between factors and sustainability performance indicators. The results highlight that all communication factors are important for organisational sustainability, albeit some more than others. The correlation analyses provide a comprehensive picture of the interconnectedness between the factors. All factors are intercorrelated according to the results. Correlation and centrality analyses indicate the importance of leadership and support in driving effective communication for sustainability, with these factors mutually reinforcing each other. The study also indicates that some communication factors are correlated with sustainability performance.

This paper provides insights into communication factors by determining the most focused on sustainability, analysing their intercorrelations, referring to the rankings across different types of organisations, and establishing connections with sustainability performance in

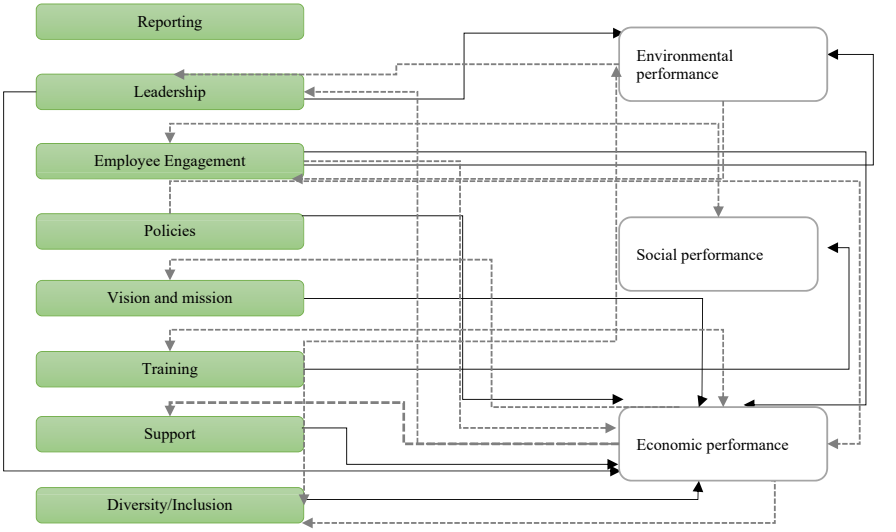


Figure 6. The connection between communication factors and sustainability performance, dashed arrows show study results; solid arrows align with literature. **Source:** Authors' own work

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

different organisational contexts. By mapping the interplay of communication factors – such as policy, support, reporting and training – this research moves beyond isolated analysis to offer a more integrated understanding of how communication structures shape sustainability outcomes. The high centrality of support and the consistent prominence of policy suggest that formal structures and cross-cutting organisational practices play a pivotal role in embedding sustainability. Improved integration of communication factors can provide organisations and their leaders with better structures to understand communication channels. Better communication channels can contribute to a more holistic implementation of sustainability and enhance sustainability performance in organisations. This can raise awareness about the sustainability efforts and catalyse sustainable change and collaboration. PSOs and CSOs could strengthen their sustainability performance by adopting more tailored and context-sensitive strategies. For instance, PSOs might implement mandatory sustainability training for managers/employees and create cross-functional sustainability teams to integrate sustainability into policy development and service delivery. CSOs could embed sustainability into their program planning by offering employee workshops that link sustainability with community engagement activities, or by developing internal systems for tracking sustainability performance. In corporations, initiatives could focus on aligning sustainability with core business operations. This may be achieved through employee-driven innovation programs and performance-based incentives tied to sustainability metrics. Embedding such targeted strategies within communication factors can enable each organisation type to enhance communication, employee engagement, improve alignment with sustainability objectives and achieve more impactful outcomes.

By understanding the centrality of different factors, organisations may optimise their communication strategies by prioritising the most interconnected factors. For example, enhancing leadership support for sustainability could facilitate better alignment between different organisational units, leading to more coherent sustainability goals and more effective implementation. Similarly, increasing the centrality of employee engagement through training and empowerment could reinforce other key factors like decision-making and career development, ultimately leading to better sustainability performance.

In terms of societal implications, this study highlights the potential for effective communication strategies to influence public policy and community engagement. By integrating sustainability-focused communication factors into policy frameworks, organisations and policymakers may create a more interconnected approach to addressing sustainability challenges. For instance, leadership and support strategies identified in this research could be incorporated into policy guidelines to promote transparency, inclusivity and stakeholder collaboration. Enhanced communication channels might also engage communities, improve the quality of life by fostering awareness of sustainability efforts, and inspire collective action toward sustainable development goals.

Despite its contributions, this study has limitations. For instance, the chosen survey method might not have adequately captured all sustainability performance indicators and the relevant communication factors related to sustainability within organisations. For example, while policies were ranked highest across all sectors, this study could not explore whether their prominence is driven by regulatory pressures, internal governance practices, or other contextual factors. Future research using qualitative methods, such as interviews or document analysis, could provide deeper insights into such motivations. Another limitation could be non-response bias, which may arise due to participants choosing not to complete the survey, potentially impacting the representativeness and accuracy of the study's findings. Although sustainability performance was measured over a five-year period, communication factors were assessed at a single point in time. Future longitudinal studies could better explore potential causal links between sustainability and communication. Also, external factors such as regulatory compliance or stakeholder engagement may mediate or moderate the relationship between sustainability communication and performance, yet, as the data used in this paper do not cover these aspects, we recommend that future research explores their potential influence.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Future research should address these limitations by considering more than one country, longitudinal designs, larger and more diverse samples, and exploring additional factors to enhance sustainability performance. Further exploration of underperforming factors, such as training, as well as the economic and societal impacts of sustainability communication, could provide actionable insights.

References

Adams, C.A., Muir, S. and Hoque, Z. (2014), "Measurement of sustainabiltiy performance in the public sector", *Sustainability Accounting Management and Policy Journal*, Vol. 5 No. 1, pp. 44-67, doi: 10.1108/SAMPJ-04-2012-0018.

Aiswarya, B. and Ramasundaram, G. (2020), "Sustainable human resource management", in *Sustainable Human Resource Management*, Springer, Singapore, doi: 10.1007/978-981-15-5656-2.

Albrecht, S.L., Bocks, A., Dalton, J., Lorigan, A. and Smith, A. (2022), "Pro-environmental employee engagement: the influence of pro-environmental organizational", Job and Personal Resources, pp. 1-19.

Allen, S. (2020), *Encyclopedia of Sustainability in Higher Education*, September, doi: 10.1007/978-3-319-63951-2.

Alon, I., Lattemann, C., Fetscherin, M., li, S. and Schneider, A.M. (2010), "Usage of public corporate communications of social responsibility in Brazil, Russia, India and China (BRIC)", *International Journal of Emerging Markets*, Vol. 5 No. 1, pp. 6-22, doi: 10.1108/17468801011018248.

Ameer, F. and Khan, N.R. (2020), "Manager's age, sustainable entrepreneurial orientation and sustainable performance: a conceptual outlook", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 12 No. 8, p. 3196, doi: 10.3390/SU12083196.

Amey, L., Plummer, R. and Pickering, G. (2020), "Website communications for campus sustainability: an analysis of Canadian universities", *International Journal of Sustainability in Higher Education*, Vol. 21 No. 3, pp. 531-556, doi: 10.1108/IJSHE-04-2019-0137.

Ammann, J., Arbenz, A., Mack, G., Nemecek, T. and El Benni, N. (2023), "A review on policy instruments for sustainable food consumption", *Sustainable Production and Consumption*, Vol. 36, pp. 338-353, doi: 10.1016/j.spc.2023.01.012.

Amran, A. and Ooi, S.K. (2014), "Sustainability reporting: meeting stakeholder demands", *Strategic Direction*, Vol. 30 No. 7, pp. 38-41, doi: 10.1108/SD-03-2014-0035.

Amran, A., Lee, S.P. and Devi, S.S. (2014), "The influence of governance structure and strategic corporate social responsibility toward sustainability reporting quality", *Business Strategy and the Environment*, Vol. 23 No. 4, pp. 217-235, doi: 10.1002/bse.1767.

Arvidsson, S. and Dumay, J. (2022), "Corporate ESG reporting quantity, quality and performance: where to now for environmental policy and practice?", *Business Strategy and the Environment*, Vol. 31 No. 3, pp. 1091-1110, doi: 10.1002/bse.2937.

Basil, D., Runte, M., Basil, M. and Usher, J. (2011), "Company support for employee volunteerism: does size matter?", *Journal of Business Research*, Vol. 64 No. 1, pp. 61-66, doi: 10.1016/j.jbusres.2009.10.002.

Batulan, C., Tan, F.T.C. and Chan, C.M.L. (2021), "Bridging the sustainability leadership chasm: a case study of the sustainability advantage program of the NSW government, Australia", *Proceedings of the Annual Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences*, 2020-Janua(February), pp. 4775-4784, doi: 10.24251/hicss.2021.579.

Becodo, R.P. (2018), "Governance communication: a primer (in the context of disaster risk reduction and management)", July.

Borgatti, S.P. (2005), "Centrality and network flow", *Social Networks*, Vol. 27 No. 1, pp. 55-71, doi: 10.1016/j.socnet.2004.11.008.

Briguglio, M. and Brown, M. (2011), "A civil society perspective of sustainable energy policy and green jobs in a small state perspective", Case Studies from Malta, April 2015.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Bryman, A. (2012), "Social research methods", *BMC Public Health*, Vol. 5 No. 1, doi: 10.1542/peds.2011-1317.

Buallay, A., Hamdan, R., Barone, E. and Hamdan, A. (2022), "Increasing female participation on boards: effects on sustainability reporting", *International Journal of Finance and Economics*, Vol. 27 No. 1, pp. 111-124, doi: 10.1002/ijfe.2141.

Carpenter, S., Takahashi, B., Lertpratchya, A.P. and Cunningham, C. (2016), "Greening the campus: a theoretical extension of the dialogic communication approach", *International Journal of Sustainability in Higher Education*, Vol. 17 No. 4, pp. 520-539, doi: 10.1108/IJSHE-02-2015-0036.

Cebrián, G., Grace, M. and Humphris, D. (2015), "Academic staff engagement in education for sustainable development", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 106, pp. 79-86, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2014.12.010.

Ceulemans, K., Molderez, I. and Van Liedekerke, L. (2015), "Sustainability reporting in higher education: a comprehensive review of the recent literature and paths for further research", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 106, pp. 127-143, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2014.09.052.

Chiraz, R. and Frioui, M. (2012), "Corporate social responsibility and global governance", *Procedia - Social and Behavioral Sciences*, Vol. 62, pp. 1174-1178, doi: 10.1016/j.sbspro.2012.09.201.

Çop, S., Olorunsola, V.O. and Alola, U.V. (2021), "Achieving environmental sustainability through green transformational leadership policy: can green team resilience help?", *Business Strategy and the Environment*, Vol. 30 No. 1, pp. 671-682, doi: 10.1002/bse.2646.

Covucci, C., Confetto, M.G., Ključnikov, A. and Panait, M. (2024), "Unrevealing the nexus between digital sustainability and corporate digital responsibility: a dual-track systematic literature review towards a framework of corporate digital sustainability", *Technology in Society*, Vol. 79, August, 102743, doi: 10.1016/j.techsoc.2024.102743.

Crane, A. and Glozer, S. (2016), "Researching corporate social responsibility communication: themes, opportunities and challenges", *Journal of Management Studies*, Vol. 53 No. 7, pp. 1223-1252, doi: 10.1111/joms.12196.

de Oliveira, U.R., Menezes, R.P. and Fernandes, V.A. (2023), "A systematic literature review on corporate sustainability: contributions, barriers, innovations and future possibilities", in *Environment, Development and Sustainability (Issue 0123456789)*, Springer, Netherlands, doi: 10.1007/s10668-023-02933-7.

Devin, B.L. and Lane, A.B. (2014), "Communicating engagement in corporate social responsibility: a meta-level construal of engagement", *Journal of Public Relations Research*, Vol. 26 No. 5, pp. 436-454, doi: 10.1080/1062726X.2014.956104.

Dey, M., Bhattacharjee, S., Mahmood, M., Uddin, M.A. and Biswas, S.R. (2022), "Ethical leadership for better sustainable performance: role of employee values, behavior and ethical climate", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 337, January, 130527, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2022.130527.

Domingues, A.R., Lozano, R., Ceulemans, K. and Ramos, T.B. (2017), "Sustainability reporting in public sector organisations: exploring the relation between the reporting process and organisational change management for sustainability", *Journal of Environmental Management*, Vol. 192, pp. 292-301, doi: 10.1016/j.jenvman.2017.01.074.

Du, S., Bhattacharya, C.B. and Sen, S. (2010), "Maximizing business returns to corporate social responsibility (CSR): the role of CSR communication", *International Journal of Management Reviews*, Vol. 12 No. 1, pp. 8-19, doi: 10.1111/j.1468-2370.2009.00276.x.

Dumay, J., Guthrie, J. and Farneti, F. (2010), "GRI sustainability reporting guidelines for public and third sector organizations: a critical review", *Public Management Review*, Vol. 12 No. 4, pp. 531-548, doi: 10.1080/14719037.2010.496266.

Encinas Bartos, K., Schwarzkopf, J. and Mueller, M. (2024), "The role of trainings in improving supplier sustainability performance", *World Development*, Vol. 175 No. December 2023, 106482, doi: 10.1016/j.worlddev.2023.106482.

Farneti, F. and Guthrie, J. (2009), "Sustainability reporting by Australian public sector organisations: why they report", *Accounting Forum*, Vol. 33 No. 2, pp. 89-98, doi: 10.1016/j.accfor.2009.04.002.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Fernández, P., Hartmann, P. and Apaolaza, V. (2022), "What drives CSR communication effectiveness on social media? A process-based theoretical framework and research agenda", *International Journal of Advertising*, Vol. 41 No. 3, pp. 385-413, doi: 10.1080/02650487.2021.1947016.

Figueira, I., Domingues, A.R., Caeiro, S., Painho, M., Antunes, P., Santos, R., Videira, N., Walker, R.M., Huisingh, D. and Ramos, T.B. (2018), "Sustainability policies and practices in public sector organisations: the case of the Portuguese Central Public Administration", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 202, pp. 616-630, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2018.07.244.

Filho, W.L., Eustachio, J.H.P.P., Caldana, A.C.F., Will, M., Salvia, A.L., Rampasso, I.S., Anholon, R., Platje, J. and Kovaleva, M. (2020), "Sustainability leadership in higher education institutions: an overview of challenges", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 12 No. 9, p. 3761, doi: 10.3390/su12093761.

Fletcher, L., Bailey, K., Alfes, K. and Madden, A. (2016), "Employee engagement in the public sector: a narrative evidence synthesis", *Academy of Management Proceedings*, Vol. 2016 No. 1, 13106, doi: 10.5465/ambpp.2016.13106abstract.

Foo, P.Y., Lee, V.H., Tan, G.W.H. and Ooi, K.B. (2018), "A gateway to realising sustainability performance via green supply chain management practices: a PLS–ANN approach", *Expert Systems with Applications*, Vol. 107, pp. 1-14, doi: 10.1016/j.eswa.2018.04.013.

Franz-Balsen, A. and Heinrichs, H. (2007), "Managing sustainability communication on campus: experiences from Lüneburg", *International Journal of Sustainability in Higher Education*, Vol. 8 No. 4, pp. 431-445, doi: 10.1108/14676370710823591.

Galletta, S., Mazzù, S., Naciti, V. and Vermiglio, C. (2022), "Gender diversity and sustainability performance in the banking industry", *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, Vol. 29 No. 1, pp. 161-174, doi: 10.1002/csr.2191.

Garay, L., Font, X. and Pereira-Moliner, J. (2017), "Understanding sustainability behaviour: the relationship between information acquisition, proactivity and performance", *Tourism Management*, Vol. 60, pp. 418-429, doi: 10.1016/j.tourman.2016.12.017.

Gehrels, S. and Suleri, J. (2016), "Diversity and inclusion as indicators of sustainable human resources management in the international hospitality industry", *Research in Hospitality Management*, Vol. 6 No. 1, pp. 61-67, doi: 10.2989/rhm.2016.6.1.8.1296.

Genç, R. (2017), "The importance of communication in sustainability and sustainable strategies", *Procedia Manufacturing*, Vol. 8 No. October 2016, pp. 511-516, doi: 10.1016/j.promfg.2017.02.065.

Golob, U., Podnar, K. and Zabkar, V. (2022), "Sustainability communication", *International Journal of Advertising*, pp. 1-10, doi: 10.1080/02650487.2022.2144035.

Guthrie, J. and Farneti, F. (2008), "GRI sustainability reporting by Australian public sector organizations", *Public Money and Management*, Vol. 28 No. 6, pp. 361-366, doi: 10.1111/j.1467-9302.2008.00670.x.

Hahn, R. and Kühnen, M. (2013), "Determinants of sustainability reporting: a review of results, trends, theory, and opportunities in an expanding field of research", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 59, pp. 5-21, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2013.07.005.

Harter, J.K., Schmidt, F.L. and Hayes, T.L. (2002), "Business-unit-level relationship between employee satisfaction, employee engagement, and business outcomes: a meta-analysis", *Journal of Applied Psychology*, Vol. 87 No. 2, pp. 268-279, doi: 10.1037/0021-9010.87.2.268.

Hayman, R. (2016), "Unpacking civil society sustainability: looking back, broader, deeper, forward", *Development in Practice*, Vol. 26 No. 5, pp. 670-680, doi: 10.1080/09614524.2016.1191439.

Hidayah, N., Badawi, A. and Nugroho, L. (2019), "Factors affecting the disclosure of sustainability reporting", *International Journal of Commerce and Finance*, Vol. 5 No. 2, pp. 219-229.

Ho Lee, T. (2017), "The status of corporate social responsibility research in public relations: a content analysis of published articles in eleven scholarly journals from 1980 to 2015", *Public Relations Review*, Vol. 43 No. 1, pp. 211-218, doi: 10.1016/j.pubrev.2016.10.001.

Hohnen, P. (2007), "Corporate social responsibility - an implementation guide for business", International Institute for Sustainable Development, doi: 10.1111/j.0955-6419.2005.00365.x.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Horak, S., Arya, B. and Ismail, K.M. (2018), "Organizational sustainability determinants in different cultural settings: a conceptual framework", *Business Strategy and the Environment*, Vol. 27 No. 4, pp. 528-546, doi: 10.1002/bse.2018.

Hörisch, J., Ortas, E., Schaltegger, S. and Álvarez, I. (2015), "Environmental effects of sustainability management tools: an empirical analysis of large companies", *Ecological Economics*, Vol. 120, pp. 241-249, doi: 10.1016/j.ecolecon.2015.11.002.

Hossin, M.A., Hosain, M.S., Frempong, M.F., Adu-Yeboah, S.S. and Mustafi, M.A.A. (2021), "What drives sustainable organizational performance? The roles of perceived organizational support and sustainable organizational reputation", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 13 No. 22, 12363, doi: 10.3390/su132212363.

Huo, B., Gu, M. and Wang, Z. (2019), "Green or lean? A supply chain approach to sustainable performance", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 216, pp. 152-166, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2019.01.141.

Hutchins, M.J. and Sutherland, J.W. (2008), "An exploration of measures of social sustainability and their application to supply chain decisions", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 16 No. 15, pp. 1688-1698, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2008.06.001.

Ibáñez-Forés, V., Martínez-Sánchez, V., Valls-Val, K. and Bovea, M.D. (2022), "Sustainability reports as a tool for measuring and monitoring the transition towards the circular economy of organisations: proposal of indicators and metrics", *Journal of Environmental Management*, Vol. 320, June, 115784, doi: 10.1016/j.jenvman.2022.115784.

Iqbal, Q., Ahmad, N.H. and Halim, H.A. (2020a), "How does sustainable leadership influence sustainable performance? Empirical evidence from selected ASEAN countries", *Sage Open*, Vol. 10 No. 4, doi: 10.1177/2158244020969394.

Iqbal, Q., Ahmad, N.H., Nasim, A. and Khan, S.A.R. (2020b), "A moderated-mediation analysis of psychological empowerment: sustainable leadership and sustainable performance", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 262, 121429, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2020.121429.

Javed, A., Iqbal, J., Iqbal, S.M.J. and Imran, M. (2021), "Sustainable leadership and employee innovative behavior: discussing the mediating role of creative self-efficacy", *Journal of Public Affairs*, Vol. 21 No. 3, doi: 10.1002/pa.2547.

Ji, Y.G., Tao, W. and Rim, H. (2022), "Theoretical insights of CSR research in communication from 1980 to 2018: a bibliometric network analysis", *Journal of Business Ethics*, Vol. 177 No. 2, pp. 327-349, doi: 10.1007/s10551-021-04748-w.

Jupp, V. (2006), "The SAGE dictionary of social research methods", in *SpringerBriefs in Computer Science*, SAGE Publications, 9783319171470, doi: 10.4135/9780857020116.

Kang, D. and Kim, S. (2017), "Conceptual model development of sustainability practices: the case of port operations for collaboration and governance", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 9 No. 12, pp. 1-15, doi: 10.3390/su9122333.

Kate Nnabuife, E., Mary Onwuka, E. and Ayatani Gilbert, F. (2015), "Employee training and organizational sustainability: a study of Bayelsa state broadcasting corporation", *IOSR Journal of Business and ManagementVer. III*, Vol. 17 No. 8, pp. 2319-7668, doi: 10.9790/487X-17838593.

Kaur, A. and Lodhia, S.K. (2019), "Key issues and challenges in stakeholder engagement in sustainability reporting: a study of Australian local councils", *Pacific Accounting Review*, Vol. 31 No. 1, pp. 2-18, doi: 10.1108/PAR-11-2017-0092.

Khatri, I. (2023), "Board gender diversity and sustainability performance: Nordic evidence", *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, Vol. 30 No. 3, pp. 1495-1507, doi: 10.1002/csr.2432.

Khunkaew, R., Wichianrak, J. and Suttipun, M. (2023), "Sustainability reporting, gender diversity, firm value and corporate performance in ASEAN region", *Cogent Business and Management*, Vol. 10 No. 1, doi: 10.1080/23311975.2023.2200608.

Klein, N., Ramos, T.B. and Deutz, P. (2020), "Circular economy practices and strategies in public sector organizations: an integrative review", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 12 No. 10, pp. 1-24, doi: 10.3390/su12104181.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Klein, N., Ramos, T.B. and Deutz, P. (2021), "Factors and strategies for circularity implementation in the public sector: an organisational change management approach for sustainability", *Corporate Social Responsibility and Environmental Management*, September, pp. 1-15, doi: 10.1002/csr.2215.

Klettner, A., Clarke, T. and Boersma, M. (2014), "The governance of corporate sustainability: empirical insights into the development, leadership and implementation of responsible business strategy", *Journal of Business Ethics*, Vol. 122 No. 1, pp. 145-165, doi: 10.1007/s10551-013-1750-y.

Kompa, K. and Witkowska, D. (2018), "Gender diversity in the boardrooms of public companies in Poland: changes and implications", *Montenegrin Journal of Economics*, Vol. 14 No. 1, pp. 79-92, doi: 10.14254/1800-5845/2018.14-1.6.

Kusi, M., Zhao, F. and Sukamani, D. (2021), "Impact of perceived organizational support and green transformational leadership on sustainable organizational performance: a SEM approach", *Business Process Management Journal*, Vol. 27 No. 5, pp. 1373-1390, doi: 10.1108/BPMJ-09-2020-0419.

Leal Filho, W., Salvia, A.L., Frankenberger, F., Akib, N.A.M., Sen, S.K., Sivapalan, S., Novo-Corti, I., Venkatesan, M. and Emblen-Perry, K. (2021), "Governance and sustainable development at higher education institutions", *Environment, Development and Sustainability*, Vol. 23 No. 4, pp. 6002-6020, doi: 10.1007/s10668-020-00859-y.

Liao, Y. (2022), "Sustainable leadership: a literature review and prospects for future research", *Frontiers in Psychology*, Vol. 13, November, pp. 1-11, doi: 10.3389/fpsyg.2022.1045570.

Lodhia, S. (2014), "Factors influencing the use of the World Wide Web for sustainability communication: an Australian mining perspective", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 84 No. 1, pp. 142-154, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2014.08.085.

Lyu, J. (2024), "How does digital leadership improve organizational sustainability: theory and evidence", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 434, November 2023, 140148, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2023.140148.

Mazo, L. and Macpherson, I. (2017), "A strategic communication model for sustainable initiatives in higher education institutions", *Athens Journal of Mass Media and Communications*, Vol. 3 No. 4, pp. 321-342, doi: 10.30958/ajmmc/3.4.3.

Millar, C., Hind, P., Millar, C., Hind, P., Millar, C. and Magala, S. (2012), "Sustainability and the need for change: organisational change and transformational vision", *Journal of Organizational Change Management*, Vol. 25 No. 4, pp. 489-500, doi: 10.1108/09534811211239272.

Moldavska, A. and Welo, T. (2018), "Testing and verification of a new corporate sustainability assessment method for manufacturing: a multiple case research study", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 10 No. 11, p. 4121, doi: 10.3390/su10114121.

Moneva, J.M., Rivera-Lirio, J.M. and Muñoz-Torres, M.J. (2007), "The corporate stakeholder commitment and social and financial performance", *Industrial Management and Data Systems*, Vol. 107 No. 1, pp. 84-102, doi: 10.1108/02635570710719070.

Morrow, D. and Rondinelli, D. (2002), "Adopting corporate environmental management systems", *European Management Journal*, Vol. 20 No. 2, pp. 159-171, doi: 10.1016/S0263-2373(02)00026-9.

Nanath, K. and Ajit Kumar, S. (2021), "The role of communication medium in increasing e-waste recycling awareness among higher educational institutions", *International Journal of Sustainability in Higher Education*, Vol. 22 No. 4, pp. 833-853, doi: 10.1108/IJSHE-10-2020-0399.

Nasreen, T., Baker, R. and Rezania, D. (2023), "Sustainability reporting – a systematic review of various dimensions, theoretical and methodological underpinnings", *Journal of Financial Reporting and Accounting*, Vol. 23 No. 3, pp. 1057-1088, doi: 10.1108/JFRA-01-2022-0029.

Newig, J., Schulz, D., Fischer, D., Hetze, K., Laws, N., Lüdecke, G. and Rieckmann, M. (2013), "Communication regarding sustainability: conceptual perspectives and exploration of societal subsystems", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 5 No. 7, pp. 2976-2990, doi: 10.3390/su5072976.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Nwagbara, U. and Reid, P. (2013), "Corporate social responsibility communication in the age of new media: towards the logic of sustainability communication", *Revista de Management Comparat International*, Vol. 14 No. 3, pp. 400-414, available at: http://search.proquest.com/docview/1466131201?accountid=10297%5Cnhttp://sfx.cranfield.ac.uk/cranfield?url_ver=Z39.88-2004&rft_val_fmt=info:ofi/fmt:kev:mtx:journal&genre=article&sid=ProQ:ProQ:abiglobal&atitle=Corporate+Social+Responsibility+Communication+i

Oelze, N., Hoejmose, S.U., Habisch, A. and Millington, A. (2016), "Sustainable development in supply chain management: the role of organizational learning for policy implementation", *Business Strategy and the Environment*, Vol. 25 No. 4, pp. 241-260, doi: 10.1002/bse.1869.

Ohlsson, C. and Riihimäki, J. (2015), "Sustainable Communication or Communicating Sustainability?: a qualitative research studying sustainable marketing practices at IBM, Max Burgers and H&M", available at: http://www.diva-portal.org/smash/record.jsf?pid=diva2:895731.

Oncioiu, I., Petrescu, A.G., Bîlcan, F.R., Petrescu, M., Popescu, D.M. and Anghel, E. (2020), "Corporate sustainability reporting and financial performance", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 12 No. 10, pp. 1-13, doi: 10.3390/su12104297.

Opoku-Dakwa, A., Chen, C.C. and Rupp, D.E. (2018), "CSR initiative characteristics and employee engagement: an impact-based perspective", *Journal of Organizational Behavior*, Vol. 39 No. 5, pp. 580-593, doi: 10.1002/job.2281.

Ortas, E., Álvarez, I. and Zubeltzu, E. (2017), "Firms' board independence and corporate social performance: a meta-analysis", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 9 No. 6, pp. 1-26, doi: 10.3390/su9061006.

Papoutsi, A. and Sodhi, M.M.S. (2020), "Does disclosure in sustainability reports indicate actual sustainability performance?", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 260, 121049, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2020.121049.

Petrini, M. and Pozzebon, M. (2010), "Integrating sustainability into business practices: learning from Brazilian firms", *BAR - Brazilian Administration Review*, Vol. 7 No. 4, pp. 362-378, doi: 10.1590/S1807-76922010000400004.

Quinn, L. and Dalton, M. (2009), "Leading for sustainability: implementing the tasks of leadership", *Corporate Governance*, Vol. 9 No. 1, pp. 21-38, doi: 10.1108/14720700910936038.

Ramos, T.B., Domingues, A.R., Caeiro, S., Cartaxo, J., Painho, M., Antunes, P., Santos, R., Videira, N., Walker, R.M. and Huisingh, D. (2021), "Co-creating a sustainability performance assessment tool for public sector organisations", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 320, July, 128738, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2021.128738.

Rieg, N.A., Gatersleben, B.C.M. and Christie, I. (2021), "Organizational change management for sustainability in higher education institutions: a systematic quantitative literature review", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 13 No. 13, p. 7299, doi: 10.3390/su13137299.

Rose, C. (2007), "Does female board representation influence firm performance? The Danish evidence", *Corporate Governance: An International Review*, Vol. 15 No. 2, pp. 404-413, doi: 10.1111/j.1467-8683.2007.00570.x.

Sánchez, R.G., Flórez-Parra, J.M., López-Pérez, M.V. and López-Hernández, A.M. (2020), "Corporate governance and disclosure of information on corporate social responsibility: an analysis of the top 200 universities in the Shanghai ranking", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 12 No. 4, pp. 1-22, doi: 10.3390/su12041549.

Saz-Gil, M.I., Cosenza, J.P., Zardoya-Alegría, A. and Gil-Lacruz, A.I. (2020), "Exploring corporate social responsibility under the background of sustainable development goals: a proposal to corporate volunteering", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 12 No. 12, p. 4811, doi: 10.3390/SU12124811.

Schaefer, S.D., Terlutter, R. and Diehl, S. (2020), "Talking about CSR matters: employees' perception of and reaction to their company's CSR communication in four different CSR domains", *International Journal of Advertising*, Vol. 39 No. 2, pp. 191-212, doi: 10.1080/02650487.2019.1593736.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Shawe, R., Horan, W., Moles, R. and O'Regan, B. (2019), "Mapping of sustainability policies and initiatives in higher education institutes", *Environmental Science and Policy*, Vol. 99, April, pp. 80-88, doi: 10.1016/j.envsci.2019.04.015.

Silva, S., Nuzum, A.K. and Schaltegger, S. (2019), "Stakeholder expectations on sustainability performance measurement and assessment. A systematic literature review", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 217, pp. 204-215, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2019.01.203.

Suriyankietkaew, S. and Avery, G.C. (2014), "Employee satisfaction and sustainable leadership practices in Thai SMEs", *Journal of Global Responsibility*, Vol. 5 No. 1, pp. 160-173, doi: 10.1108/JGR-02-2014-0003.

Székely, F. and Knirsch, M. (2005), "Responsible leadership and corporate social responsibility: metrics for sustainable performance", *European Management Journal*, Vol. 23 No. 6, pp. 628-647, doi: 10.1016/j.emj.2005.10.009.

Tetrevova, L. and Jelinkova, M. (2019), "Municipal social responsibility of statutory cities in the Czech Republic", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 11 No. 8, p. 2308, doi: 10.3390/su11082308.

Tharenou, P., Saks, A.M. and Moore, C. (2007), "A review and critique of research on training and organizational-level outcomes", *Human Resource Management Review*, Vol. 17 No. 3, pp. 251-273, doi: 10.1016/j.hrmr.2007.07.004.

Tölkes, C. (2020), "The role of sustainability communication in the attitude–behaviour gap of sustainable tourism", *Tourism and Hospitality Research*, Vol. 20 No. 1, pp. 117-128, doi: 10.1177/1467358418820085.

Traxler, A.A., Schrack, D. and Greiling, D. (2020), "Sustainability reporting and management control – a systematic exploratory literature review", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 276, 122725, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2020.122725.

Tsalis, T.A., Terzaki, M., Koulouriotis, D., Tsagarakis, K.P. and Nikolaou, I.E. (2022), "The nexus of United Nations' 2030 Agenda and corporate sustainability reports", *Sustainable Development*, September 2022, pp. 784-796, doi: 10.1002/sd.2419.

Van Grinsven, M. and Visser, M. (2011), "Empowerment, knowledge conversion and dimensions of organizational learning", *The Learning Organization*, Vol. 18 No. 5, pp. 378-391, doi: 10.1108/09696471111151729.

van Hoof, B. (2014), "Organizational learning in cleaner production among Mexican supply networks", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 64, pp. 115-124, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2013.07.041.

Verburg, R.M., Nienaber, A.-M., Searle, R.H., Weibel, A., Den Hartog, D.N. and Rupp, D.E. (2018), "The role of organizational control systems in employees' organizational trust and performance outcomes", *Group and Organization Management*, Vol. 43 No. 2, pp. 179-206, doi: 10.1177/1059601117725191.

Verk, N., Golob, U. and Podnar, K. (2021), "A dynamic review of the emergence of corporate social responsibility communication", *Journal of Business Ethics*, Vol. 168 No. 3, pp. 491-515, doi: 10.1007/s10551-019-04232-6.

Viererbl, B. and Koch, T. (2022), "The paradoxical effects of communicating CSR activities: why CSR communication has both positive and negative effects on the perception of a company's social responsibility", *Public Relations Review*, Vol. 48 No. 1, 102134, doi: 10.1016/j.pubrev.2021.102134.

Walliman, N. (2011), "Research methods: the basics", *Indonesian EFL Journal*, Vol. 5 No. 2, doi: 10.25134/ieflj.v5i2.1835.

Xie, M., Qiu, Y., Liang, Y., Zhou, Y., Liu, Z. and Zhang, G. (2022), "Policies, applications, barriers and future trends of building information modeling technology for building sustainability and informatization in China", *Energy Reports*, Vol. 8, pp. 7107-7126, doi: 10.1016/j.egyr.2022.05.008.

Yang, J. and Basile, K. (2022), "Communicating corporate social responsibility: external stakeholder involvement, productivity and firm performance", *Journal of Business Ethics*, Vol. 178 No. 2, pp. 501-517, doi: 10.1007/s10551-021-04812-5.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

yED (2019), "yEd Graph Editor", [Computer software], yWorks GmbH, Tübingen, Germany, available at: https://www.yworks.com/products/yed

Zhang, L., Guo, X., Lei, Z. and Lim, M.K. (2019), "Social network analysis of sustainable human resource management from the employee training's perspective", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 11 No. 2, p. 380, doi: 10.3390/su11020380.

Zhao, F., Kang, T.W. and Kang, M. (2022), "Linking intellectual leadership practices to sustainability outcomes: moderated mediation effect of employees' multifunctionality", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 14 No. 7, p. 3855, doi: 10.3390/su14073855.

Further reading

Arioglu, E. (2020), "Female board members: the effect of director affiliation", *Gender in Management: An International Journal*, Vol. 35 No. 2, pp. 225-254, doi: 10.1108/GM-05-2019-0080.

Arosa, B., Iturralde, T. and Maseda, A. (2013), "The board structure and firm performance in SMEs: evidence from Spain", *Investigaciones Europeas de Dirección y Economía de La Empresa*, Vol. 19 No. 3, pp. 127-135, doi: 10.1016/j.iedee.2012.12.003.

Casey, D. and Sieber, S. (2016), "Employees, sustainability and motivation: increasing employee engagement by addressing sustainability and corporate social responsibility", *Research in Hospitality Management*, Vol. 6 No. 1, pp. 69-76, doi: 10.2989/rhm.2016.6.1.9.1297.

Dalal-Clayton, B. and Bass, S. (2002), *Sustainable Development Strategies: A Resource Book*, OECD, Paris.

Duygulu, E., Ozeren, E., Işıldar, P. and Appolloni, A. (2016), "The sustainable strategy for small and medium sized enterprises: the relationship between mission statements and performance", *Sustainability*, Vol. 8 No. 7, p. 698, doi: 10.3390/su8070698.

Dyer, G. and Dyer, M. (2017), "Strategic leadership for sustainability by higher education: the American College and university Presidents' climate commitment", *Journal of Cleaner Production*, Vol. 140, pp. 111-116, doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2015.08.077.

Girón, A., Kazemikhasragh, A., Cicchiello, A.F. and Panetti, E. (2021), "Sustainability reporting and firms' economic performance: evidence from Asia and Africa", *Journal of the Knowledge Economy*, Vol. 12 No. 4, pp. 1741-1759, doi: 10.1007/s13132-020-00693-7.

Iqbal, Q., Ahmad, N.H., Li, Z. and Li, Y. (2022), "To walk in beauty: sustainable leadership, frugal innovation and environmental performance", *Managerial and Decision Economics*, Vol. 43 No. 3, pp. 738-750, doi: 10.1002/mde.3415.

Jing, F.F., Avery, G.C. and Bergsteiner, H. (2014), "Enhancing performance in small professional firms through vision communication and sharing", *Asia Pacific Journal of Management*, Vol. 31 No. 2, pp. 599-620, doi: 10.1007/s10490-013-9345-9.

Liu, S. and Yan, M.-R. (2018), "Corporate sustainability and green innovation in an emerging economy—an empirical study in China", *Sustainability*, Vol. 10 No. 11, p. 3998, doi: 10.3390/su10113998.

Patil, J.S. and Sarode, A.P. (2020), "Contribution of employees: engagement and participation of employees in green HRM to achieve sustainability", Researchgate.Net, June.

Pearce, J.A. and David, F. (1987), "Corporate mission statements: the bottom line", *Academy of Management Executive*, Vol. 1, pp. 109-115, doi: 10.5465/AME.1987.4275821.

Ramus, C.A. (2001), "Organizational support for employees: encouraging creative ideas for environmental sustainability", Vol. 43 No. 3, pp. 85-105, doi: 10.2307/41166090.

Suriyankietkaew, S. and Avery, G. (2016), "Sustainable leadership practices driving financial performance: empirical evidence from Thai SMEs", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 8 No. 4, p. 327, doi: 10.3390/su8040327.

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025

Suriyankietkaew, S., Krittayaruangroj, K. and Iamsawan, N. (2022), "Sustainable leadership practices and competencies of SMEs for sustainability and resilience: a community-based social enterprise study", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 14 No. 10, pp. 1-36, doi: 10.3390/su14105762.

Wu, L., Subramanian, N., Abdulrahman, M.D., Liu, C., Lai, K.hung and Pawar, K.S. (2015), "The impact of integrated practices of lean, green, and social management systems on firm sustainability performance-evidence from Chinese fashion auto-parts suppliers", *Sustainability (Switzerland)*, Vol. 7 No. 4, pp. 3838-3858, doi: 10.3390/su7043838.

Corresponding author
Melis Temel can be contacted at: mestel@hig.se

For instructions on how to order reprints of this article, please visit our website:
www.emeraldgrouppublishing.com/licensing/reprints.htm
Or contact us for further details: **permissions@emeraldinsight.com**

Downloaded from http://www.emerald.com/ccij/article-pdf/30/7/95/10190869/ccij-01-2025-0004en.pdf by University of Gävle user on 12 September 2025